

Yi Zhang

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PhD Candidate in Social Psychology | UX Researcher with 8+ years of experience in qualitative and quantitative methods, translating user insights into actionable strategies that inform product design and user experience.

EXPERIENCE

University of Southern California

PhD Researcher

Los Angeles, CA

2020 – Present

- Designed and conducted 10+ behavioral studies (N=4000+) on social connection and well-being, generating insights into improving connection and social engagement and publishing three first-author papers.
- Dissertation: Designed and tested a mindfulness intervention (N=180) promoting tolerance for opposing views, generating recommendations for managing real-world interpersonal conflict.
- Developed reproducible pipelines in Python, R, and SQL to analyze survey, behavioral, and text data; applied advanced statistics to produce actionable insights.

Flourish Science

UX Research Intern

Remote

Jul 2024 – Jan 2025

- Designed and evaluated a digital well-being prototype (*reaching out to old friends*) grounded in social psychology; approved and waitlisted for product launch.
- Designed and tested the Mood Map, a digital mood tracker based on React + SQL; conducted survey and workshops to gather user insights, expanding user base by over 50 people.
- Conducted mixed-methods research (interviews and surveys) to identify pain points and optimize human-AI interaction, improving prototype activity completion and engagement rates.
- Collaborated with designers, engineers, and behavioral scientists to integrate findings into product workflow and strategy.

Letters to Strangers

Lead Researcher

Remote

Oct 2023 – Present

- Led a 12-week RCT of a letter-writing intervention; treatment group showed 20% higher well-being at 6-month follow-up.
- Applied LIWC sentiment analysis and thematic analysis to letters, integrating qualitative themes with quantitative text analysis to identify language features linked to well-being improvements.
- Partnered with program directors and student leaders to translate findings into scalable mental health programming.

Columbia University

Lab Manager & Research Coordinator

New York, NY

2018 – 2020

- Coordinated a multi-site social network study (N=800+), supporting 10+ publications and \$1M+ in grants.
- Automated network data curation and analysis workflows, improving reproducibility and efficiency across sites.
- Analyzed group drinking behavior with advanced models; delivered recommendations for reducing risk behaviors and improving group dynamics among college students.

EDUCATION

University of Southern California, Los Angeles, CA

Expected May 2026

Ph.D., Social Psychology

New York University, New York, NY

May 2018

B.A., Psychology (Honors) & Philosophy

SKILLS

Research Methods: Mixed-methods research, A/B testing, surveys, interviews, usability testing, log studies

Statistical Analysis: Regression, multilevel modeling, significance testing, NLP, Bayesian analysis, social network analysis

Programming & Pipelines: Python, R, SQL, Git, Bash

Tools & Platforms: RMarkdown, Qualtrics, Tableau, NVivo, Pavlovia, CloudResearch, Prolific, UserTesting